turmoil.' He added at the 2000 AGM that a 'buyback was best resorted to when a company was profitable and cash-rich with no pressing need for funds'.

But the situation became worse. Questions were even raised about the company remaining within the Tata fold. But Ratan stood his ground. He answered his critics by saying, 'Tata Chemicals is one of our core companies and there is no change to that.' Faced with strong headwinds, Ratan, in a step designed to strengthen the company, decided to merge its 'cash rich wholly-owned subsidiary, Sabras Investment and Trading Co.' with the parent company. He said that it was a 'prudent move', designed to 'remove the corporate barriers' and help with the 'unhindered flow of financial and managerial resources'.

As Tata Chemicals expanded, Ratan riveted his attention to its core businesses. It exited the detergents business. Ratan explained that the move was necessary and 'part of a strategy planned by the group to improve the ailing TCL'. The two Tata detergent brands, Shudh and Rakshak, had very limited market penetration and there appeared little justification to continue with them. Detergents were a 'suboptimal business', contributing 'less than 2 per cent' of the company's turnover, says Menon.

As a part of the reprioritization, Ratan decided to sell the cements division of the company as well. Tata Chemicals was now only 'concentrating on its three core businesses—soda ash, salt and fertilisers'.

During the restructuring efforts, two unexpected events threatened to bedevil Ratan's bold ambitions. The first was a fire in the Mithapur plant and the other, the devastating earthquake, also in Gujarat, both of which occurred in 2001. The former resulted in a slump in the sales of fertilizers. But Ratan assured everyone that the company, with its cash surplus, would tide over the difficulties.

Confident of steering the transformation, he continued his efforts at modernizing the company and expanding its activities. In 2002, the Mithapur plant was awarded the ISO 14001 certificate—a recognition of high quality achieved in compliance with certain environmental and management systems. As a part of the policy to expand the core businesses, in 2003, Tata Chemicals decided to acquire Hind Lever Chemicals, the chemicals and fertilizer subsidiary of Hindustan Lever Limited. Ratan announced this at the AGM held in December 2003. He reiterated that 'in order to bring in efficiency and greater focus on business growth', Tata